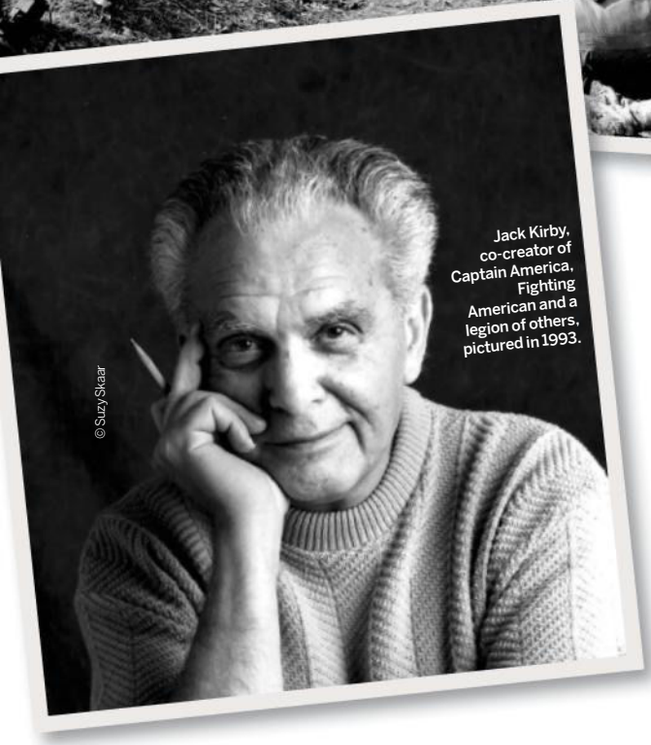




Jack Kirby, co-creator of Captain America, Fighting American and a legion of others, pictured in 1993.

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FREEDOM'S FIGHTERS

Who are the most patriotic superheroes?









UNCLE SAM

Not that Uncle Sam, but a hero formed whenever the spirit of America binds itself to a dying patriot. Hosts for the spirit have included a revolutionary war hero, a fighter from WWI and Samuel, a WWII soldier.

First Appearance: *National Comics* #1

Patriot Points: The founding fathers themselves created the American spirit during some patriotic hi-jinks. Plus, his superpowers wax and wane according to the strength of American citizens' faith in freedom and liberty.

CAPTAIN FLAG

Tom Townsend was about to be killed by kidnappers when an eagle smashed through the window and carried him off to safety. Captain Flag was born.

First Appearance: *Blue Ribbon Comics* #16

Patriot Points: His sidekick is the symbol of American glory, the eagle; specifically, a bird called Yank the Eagle (that's not a euphemism). Yank was so patriotic, she even brought an American flag back to the nest, which Tom repurposed as his costume.

STAR SPANGLED KID

Kid hero Sylvester Pemberton took on the superhero mantle after Nazi sympathisers threatened to disrupt a 4 July celebration.

First Appearance: *Star-Spangled Comics* #1

Patriot Points: Despite having no superpowers, the Star-Spangled Kid made it his duty to fight off fascism with the aid of his mechanic sidekick Stripsey. Plus, anyone willing to bear the weight of the moniker Star-Spangled Kid is probably due some props just for ridiculous patriotism.

LIBERTY BELLE

Like many Forties heroes, Libby Lawrence saw the horrors of Nazism first-hand when her father was killed in Poland. After a daring escape across the Channel, she assumed the alter-ego Liberty Belle as a tribute to the Liberty Bell.

First Appearance: *Boy Commandos* #1

Patriot Points: she shares a mystical connection with the famous Liberty Bell itself, gaining super-strength and other powers whenever the bell is rung.

they had used WWII plots. The most extreme example was Quality Comics' *T-Man*, which followed the thrilling exploits of a US Treasury agent (it managed to last from 1951 to 1956). When Captain America returned in the 1954 to do battle with communism, readers no longer appeared willing to accept blind devotion to nationalism. During the McCarthy years, patriotism was co-opted by jingoistic zeal, so when Captain America decided to wage war on communists, comic fans were unimpressed; his books sold poorly, and the run was cancelled. That same year, Kirby and Simon went hunting for reds under the bed with Prize Comics' *Fighting American*. Though their title took a swerve into the satirical and the ridiculous, he lasted only seven issues. It seemed that even the fathers of the form couldn't make flag-clad superheroes cool anymore.

Jump forward to 22 July 2011. A flash of red, white and blue bounds across the screen, and a familiar round shield glints in the light. *Captain America: The First Avenger* opens and grosses over $65 million in the first weekend. His path back into the consciousness not only of comic fans, but of the wider world audience, led to three solo-title movies and juicy parts in the *Avengers Assemble* franchise.

How did Captain America manage to avoid obscurity when so many other patriot-themed heroes failed?

A cynical view is that the nation's ego would be soothed by the re-emergence of a hero who confirms its own goodness and superiority. But is that fair? Certainly on first appearance, Captain America seems little more than the embodiment of a country's pride: after all, he does dress in a deconstructed American flag, and his name misses subtlety by a wide margin, while his devotion to the military and American ideals only confirm this. Nostalgia surely played some part in Cap's popularity, too; who wouldn't like to curl up with a childhood hero who echoed the supposedly 'easy' moral choices of the past?

But Cap's third coming also coincided with a nation fractured and no longer united by a common outside enemy. "When he comes back he is much more consumed with the internal divisions within the United States than in foreign intervention," notes Mark White, professor and author of *The Virtues Of Captain America: Modern-Day Lessons On Character From A World War II Superhero*. "He still believes in the system – it's the people in the system that often let the country down." While in the past Rogers embodied everything America thought of itself, now he took on the spirit of an America less certain of its own superiority, but still sure that the founding principles of liberty, truth and equality were the best the country had to offer.

"His patriotism is a very cosmopolitan patriotism, and he not only holds his own government to those ideals, but also demands that they be extended to people of every nation. He may have learned those ideals as an American, but he applies them universally throughout the world." continues White.

White explains his own view of Cap's longevity. "Two reasons, one perhaps more realistic and the other which I prefer," he laughs. "The first is that Cap had the better writers and stories, and he had the marketing might of the Marvel Comics machine – also known as Stan Lee – behind ⇒



Miss America was another popular all-American superhero